DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Who Sets the Limits of Evil?

Daat Tevunot §118

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §118 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 27 March 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: imperfect is not the same as bad

The class continued halfway through §118, page 264. We have been discussing the boundaries of evil. The root of evil is that the hashpaah does not come down complete; Hashem would have wanted a perfect hashpaah, but for the purposes we discussed it did not happen, and so all physical existence is imperfect and must come to an end.

The Rabbi gave an advance warning of a point the Ramhal would soon make explicit: imperfect does not mean bad. "Relative to Hashem, the malakhim are imperfect." That does not make them bad.

Evil is measured

The Ramhal continues at the bottom of page 264. The hashpaah through which God created nature contains both good and bad. But it is never a hashpaah that is completely bad, because then things would cease to exist. It has limits on how far it can go of its own accord, and it depends on Hashem's will. It comes in exactly the amount needed for things to exist.

Sometimes there is more, sometimes less. The Rabbi mentioned, without endorsing it, a Hasidic idea that some times of the year have more ra in the world. Other times have far less: Rosh Hashanah, Yom Kippur, the night of Pesah.

So the boundaries of evil are precise: enough to let evil exist, but not enough to let it take control. If ra took dominion, things would cease to exist.

Why things come to an end

The Ramhal says two things here. First, Hashem could have made everything perfect, but that would defeat the purpose of existence, which is that there should be bad in the world for us to overcome. Second, He built in the possibility of things ending, in case it would be needed.

The Rabbi connected this to the sin of Adam. Had Adam not sinned, there would have been no destruction and no death; the world and man would have stayed as they were. As learned before, the grave is part of the tikkun of Adam. So, taking up a participant's point from the week before, the laws of nature before the sin were different from the laws after it. Adam became mortal only because of the sin. But the very possibility of bitul, of things ceasing, had

to be part of creation, because before the universe there is no such concept. From God's perspective, things coming to an end is incomprehensible.

A paradox about the end of days

God makes sure the emanation does not go so far that things cease entirely, until the set time. The Rabbi pointed out a paradox. At the end of days all ra will be eradicated. But ra here does not mean only what we think of as evil. It means everything imperfect, and that includes this world itself. So this world too will end, but only at the time that has been set. Until then, evil must have a boundary so that it does not take over.

Concealment and illumination

The Ramhal repeats the foundation: the way God runs the world rests on two things, hester and heara, concealment and illumination. Their results are perfection and imperfection; perfection brings good and imperfection brings bad. Because Hashem wanted us to have a soul and a body, He "had to, as it were, control Himself" and always hold both attributes, middat hester panim and middat hearat panim, running the world with both. That produces all parts of man: the weak and the strong, the noble and the less noble.

Angels, men, animals and the sitra ahra

On page 270 the Ramhal makes the point he had promised: something can be imperfect without being bad. The angels are deficient, since there are ten levels of angels and even the top level is not perfect, yet no one would call them bad. They have no jealousy, no hatred, no evil inclination, no sleep, no death.

Humans are lower: their deficiency is so great that there is real bad in them, with death and base instincts. Animals are lower still, without speech or intellect. And lowest are the negative forces that are actually bad. They are the concealment itself, the things from which God completely hides. In the Kabbalah they are called the sitra ahra, "the other side".

Pesah was a week away, and the Rabbi applied this to the blood on the doorposts. Why was it needed? Because once the destroying forces are given permission to strike the firstborn, "where are they going to stop?" Of course Hashem is always in control, but the blood was the way not to be exposed to the randomness of the mashhit. You have to show that you are not part of it.

The chain and the creation of measure

The Ramhal says the whole chain of descent is what creates bad: each level flows from the one above, with more concealment, more imperfection, and finally more bad. The Rabbi stressed that "up" is only a figure of speech: "Hashem is not up more than He's down." We say up because humans associate importance with height.

Another creation was needed: measurement. Before the world, there is no concept of amount with God, since anything measured is finite. Time too is a creation; it measures past, present and future. When God wanted this system, He had to create measure, so He could set how

much bad and how much good there would be at each level. All of this was part of His initial will.

Body and soul

Because Hashem holds both attributes, there is soul and body, with the body lower than the soul. That alone does not make it bad. "I need sleep, I need food. That's imperfect. It's not bad yet." But since Hashem wanted bad to exist too, He made a greater concealment, and that creates evil in humans, things that cease to exist, and the need for judgment and exact measure. This would be explained further in the next class.

Summary

- Evil is precisely measured: enough to exist, never enough to take control and end existence.
- The possibility of things ending was built into creation and became real with the sin of Adam; at the end of days everything imperfect, including this world, will end at its set time.
- God runs the world with two attributes, concealment and illumination; their mix produces body and soul and all levels of creation.
- Imperfect is not bad: angels are imperfect but not bad; humans contain bad; the sitra ahra is pure concealment.
- Measurement and time are themselves creations, made so that evil could exist within limits.

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